BONUS 4

How to Get Your First Clients

A practical plan for your first months



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> *Learning to cut hair is one skill. Building a steady chair is another. This guide walks you through the practical steps of finding your first clients: practicing safely, building a portfolio, setting up your online presence, choosing where to work, setting your first prices, and keeping people coming back. It is a practical roadmap, not a guarantee. Your results depend on your local market, your effort, your skill, and the rules where you live.*

1. An Honest Mindset

Before anything else, set realistic expectations. Nobody can promise you a certain number of clients or a certain income, and this guide does not. Some people fill their book in a few weeks. Others need several months of steady work. Both are normal.

What you can control is the quality of your work, your consistency, your hygiene, how you treat people, and how often you show up where potential clients can see you. Those four habits matter more than any trick.

> **What to expect**
>
> Your first clients will mostly come from people who already know you. Treat each of them as a chance to earn a repeat visit and a referral. Growth in this trade is usually slow at first and then compounds through word of mouth.

Habits that build a reputation

- Arrive on time, every time. Punctuality is part of the service.
- Finish what you start. A clean neckline and a tidy station are part of the cut.
- Be honest about your level. Tell people when a style is outside your current skill instead of risking a bad result.
- Keep learning. Rewatch lessons, practice the same fade until it is consistent, and ask experienced barbers for feedback.
- Protect your name. One careless, unsanitary visit can cost you more clients than ten good ones win.

2. Legal Basics: Licenses, Insurance, and Local Rules

Rules for cutting hair for money differ a great deal from one country, state, province, or city to the next. This section gives general orientation only. It is not legal advice.

> **Important**
>
> Your Certificate of Completion from this course shows that you finished the course. It is NOT a barber license, a cosmetology license, or a permit to work. Check your local licensing requirements before you charge anyone for a haircut.

Questions to answer before you charge

1. Does my area require a barber or cosmetology license to cut hair for pay? What training hours, exams, and fees does it require?
2. Is there an apprenticeship route, and does a licensed barber need to supervise me?
3. Do I need a business registration, a tax number, or a local business permit, even as a sole operator?
4. Are there health or sanitation rules for the place where I work, such as inspection requirements, approved disinfectants, or rules for single-use items?
5. Are there extra rules for mobile or home-based services?
6. Do I need liability insurance, or does the shop where I rent a chair require it?

The best places to find answers are your local barbering or cosmetology licensing board, your city or county business office, and a tax professional who can explain how self-employment works where you live. Write down the answers and keep copies of anything you file.

About insurance

General liability insurance can help cover claims if a client is injured or property is damaged during a service. Some shops require proof of coverage from renters. Policies and prices vary widely, so ask an insurance professional what fits your situation and compare more than one quote. Do not assume your home or personal policy covers professional work.

3. Practicing with Models

Courses and videos teach you the steps, but your hands learn only by repetition on real heads of hair. The goal of the practice phase is to build consistency, speed, and confidence before you ask the public to trust you.

Where to practice

- Mannequin heads for basic clipper control, blending, and line work. They do not move or complain, which makes them ideal for early repetition.
- Willing models, such as friends and family who agree to be practice clients.
- Supervised practice if you are in a school or apprenticeship program, where a licensed professional checks your work.

> **Practice rules**
>
> Where a license is required, you may only practice on live models in the setting your local rules allow, such as a school or under supervision. Check this first. Practicing on people is a responsibility, not a casual hobby.

Consent comes first

Every model should know they are helping you practice. Tell them your experience level, what you plan to do, and how long it will take. Let them stop at any time. Never change their style beyond what you agreed on.

If you want to photograph or film the result, get permission before you take the picture and before you post it. Ask in plain words: 'May I take photos of the cut and share them on my portfolio page?' A written message or a signed note is better than a verbal yes you might forget. Respect a no without pressure, and remove a photo if someone asks later.

Practice with a purpose

1. Choose one skill per session, such as a low fade, a clean neckline, or a scissor-over-comb blend.
2. Do a 2-minute consultation with your model before starting. Agree on the guard numbers and the shape.
3. Work slowly and check your blend in different light and from several angles.
4. Time yourself. Early on, accuracy matters more than speed, but you should notice your time improving.
5. Ask for honest feedback on the finish, the comfort, and the experience.
6. Write down what went well and what to fix next time.

Document the work

Keep a simple practice log. After every cut, record the date, the style, the guards and tools you used, the time it took, and one thing to improve. Add a photo only if the model gave permission. After a month you will see patterns, and you will also have material to review when you build your portfolio.

DATE	STYLE	TOOLS AND GUARDS	TIME	NOTE FOR NEXT TIME
Example	Mid fade with scissor top	Clippers, guards #1 to #3, shears	50 min	Blend at the temple was uneven. Slow down there.
Example	Taper with clean neckline	Clippers, trimmer, guard #2	35 min	Neckline was good. Check the sideburn symmetry.

4. Building a Portfolio

A portfolio is simple proof of what you can do. Most people will judge you by photos before they ever sit in your chair. Quality and honesty matter more than quantity. Ten clean, well-lit photos beat fifty blurry ones.

Get permission first

- Ask every client or model before taking photos and again before posting.

- Offer to leave out their face or name if they prefer. A back or side view shows the haircut without identifying the person.
- Do not post photos of minors without a parent or guardian's clear permission.
- Never post someone else's work as your own. Use only haircuts you actually performed.

Shots every haircut needs

Take the same set of angles every time so your portfolio looks consistent and professional:

1. **Front:** head level and straight, showing the hairline and the shape of the top.
2. **Left profile:** shows the fade, the temple, and the sideburn.
3. **Right profile:** do both sides, because small differences show up here.
4. **Back:** shows the neckline and the blend at the nape.
5. **Top:** useful for textured tops, flat tops, and parts.
6. **Detail:** a close-up of a clean line, a part, or a design.

Before and after

A before photo shows the starting point, and an after photo shows what you changed. Use the same angle, distance, background, and light for both. Do not edit the after photo to look sharper or smoother than the real result. Heavy filters can hide your fade and make potential clients distrust you.

Light and background

- Natural light from a window is the easiest option. Place your client so the light falls on the side of their head, not directly behind them.
- Avoid harsh overhead lights that create shadows over the fade.
- Use a plain, uncluttered wall as a background.
- Clean the hair and shoulders. Brush off loose hair before photographing.
- Hold the camera steady at head height. Use the rear camera of your phone and wipe the lens first.

> **Tip**
>
> Short videos of the final result turning slowly can show blending better than photos. Same rule applies: get permission first.

Where to keep it

Start with a dedicated photo album on your phone, then post your best work to a social profile and your business listing. A simple page with six to twelve of your best cuts, grouped by style, is enough to start.

5. Your Online Presence

Most people now search online for a barber before they book. A clear profile makes you look reliable and helps strangers find you.

Social profile checklist

- Use one clear, consistent name across platforms, ideally your name or your business name.
- Use a clean profile photo: a friendly headshot or your logo.
- Write a short bio that says what you do, the area you serve, and how to book. Keep it simple, with no exaggerated claims.
- Pin or highlight your best portfolio posts so they appear first.
- Post regularly, such as before and after photos, short clips of a finishing step, and tips about hair care.
- Use local words and place names in captions so nearby people find you.
- Reply to messages and comments promptly and politely.

Setting up a Google Business Profile: general steps

A free business listing on a major search and map service can put you in front of people looking for a barber nearby. The exact screens and rules change over time and differ by country, so treat these steps as a general outline.

1. Sign in with a business or dedicated account, not a shared personal one.
2. Search for your business name to see whether a listing already exists. If it does, follow the steps to claim it.
3. Add your business name, category (for example, barber shop), and service area or location.
4. Decide whether to show an address. If you work from home or travel to clients, you may be able to hide the address and list a service area instead. Only share what you are comfortable making public.
5. Add your opening hours and keep them accurate.
6. Complete the verification process the service requires. This can take time.
7. Add photos from your portfolio (with permission), a short description, and a list of services.
8. Turn on booking or messaging features if they are available in your area.
9. Review your listing monthly and update hours during holidays.

> **Be accurate**
>
> Only list services you are legally allowed and able to provide. Do not use fake reviews, fake addresses, or false claims. They can get your listing removed and damage trust.

6. Where to Work

There are three common paths for a new barber. Each has trade-offs, and many people start with one and move to another later. Local rules apply to all of them.

OPTION	HOW IT WORKS	PROS	THINGS TO CONSIDER
Employee at a barbershop	The shop provides the space, tools, and often walk-in traffic.	Steady environment, mentoring, built-in clients, less startup cost.	You usually follow the shop's rules, pricing, and schedule. Pay structures vary.
Chair rental or booth rental	You pay the owner a fee for a chair or station and run your own book.	More control over your prices, hours, and brand.	You carry your own costs, taxes, insurance, and supplies. You must find your own clients.
Mobile or at-home service	You work in your own space or travel to clients.	Low overhead and flexible hours.	Many places restrict home-based or mobile haircuts. Sanitation and insurance rules can be strict.

Questions to ask a shop

- How is pay structured, and how often am I paid?
- Who supplies towels, capes, disinfectant, and products?
- Do clients book through the shop, or do I bring my own?
- What are the hours and the expectations on days off?
- Is there a written agreement? Read it before you sign.
- What does the shop require for licensing and insurance?

If you work from home or travel

Check local rules for home-based and mobile services before you accept your first booking. Some areas require a separate permit, a dedicated room, or an inspection. Whatever the rules, set up a clean station: a washable cape, fresh towels or disposable neck strips, a covered tool tray, a broom, a trash bag with a lid, and a disinfecting routine you can finish between every client. When traveling, keep tools in a closed, clean case. Tell someone where you are going, and meet new clients in safe, appropriate places.

7. Setting Your First Prices

Pricing is uncomfortable for most beginners. Charging too little can make you look inexperienced and burn you out. Charging too much too early can leave your chair empty. The answer is somewhere in the middle, and it depends on where you live.

> **Check your local market**
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> This guide does not list market rates, because they vary widely by city, shop type, and experience. Look at three to five barbers near you at a similar level, notice what they charge for a basic haircut, then set your price around that range. In many places a newer barber charges somewhat below an established one. Always check your local market.

A simple way to calculate

Start with the time a service takes plus your costs. The table below uses made-up numbers only to show the method. Replace them with your own.

ITEM	EXAMPLE FIGURE	YOUR FIGURE
Time per haircut including consultation and cleanup	45 minutes	
Setup and disinfection between clients	10 minutes	
Total time per client	55 minutes	
Supplies per client (neck strips, disinfectant, razor blade, products)	about 1.50	
Chair rental or shop fee, spread per client	about 5.00	
Hourly amount you would like to earn	about 15.00	
Rough minimum price: (hourly amount x total hours) + supplies + fee	about 20.25	

In the example, 15.00 per hour for 55 minutes is about 13.75, plus 1.50 for supplies and 5.00 for the fee, giving roughly 20.25. This is only arithmetic with sample numbers, not a recommended price or a typical rate. Compare your result to local prices. If it is far above or below, adjust either your price or your costs.

Pricing tips for beginners

- Decide your price before you post it, and stick to it with each client.
- Offer a simple menu: haircut, fade, beard trim, haircut plus beard. Fewer options are easier to explain.
- A modest introductory price for your first few clients is fine. Say it is introductory and when it ends.
- Raise your price gradually as your skill and demand grow, and give regular clients notice.
- Do not give away free work repeatedly. Free cuts are for practice with agreed models, not for a long-term plan.
- Remember tips, taxes, and fees. Track what you earn and spend from day one.

8. Your First 10 Clients

Ten is a small, useful goal. Reaching ten means you have practiced the whole service, collected feedback, and started word of mouth. These are the most common places to find them.

Friends and family

These are the easiest first clients because they already trust you. Be professional anyway: book a time, use your full process, and ask for honest feedback. If you charge, tell them the price in advance. If you discount, say so clearly. Ask them to recommend you only if they are happy.

Gyms and fitness communities

People who care about their appearance often care about grooming. Ask the manager before you put up a flyer or leave cards. Do not pitch to members while they are working out. Offer something helpful, such as a short grooming tip page.

Sports teams and clubs

Local teams often want neat haircuts for games and photos. Contact a coach, a team captain, or a parent group. Offer a team day where players can book short slots. Follow the rules for minors: get parent permission and keep the visit open and professional.

Schools and events

Before school dances, graduations, weddings, and community events, people look for a fresh cut. Ask event organizers, or offer pre-event slots. Check the venue's rules and your local licensing rules first.

Referrals

A referral is the strongest source of clients because it comes with trust. Make it easy: after a great visit, say 'If you know someone who might like a cut like this, I would love to meet them.' Some barbers offer a small thank-you, such as a discount on a future visit. Keep it simple and fair.

Ten message scripts

Copy, change the words to sound like you, and replace the fields in [brackets]. Keep every message short, polite, and easy to answer. Never send the same message to a large list of strangers.

1. **Friend (first booking):** 'Hi [Name], I am taking on my first regular clients and would love to cut your hair. I have openings on [Day] and [Day]. Want to grab a slot?'
2. **Family member:** 'Hey [Name], I have finished my barber training and I am building my portfolio. Could I give you a fresh cut this week? I will ask your permission before taking any photos.'
3. **Introductory price offer:** 'Hi [Name], I am offering an introductory price of [Price] for new clients until [Date]. If you want a clean cut or a fade, I can fit you in on [Day].'
4. **Gym manager:** 'Hi [Name], I am a local barber. Would it be okay to leave a few cards or post a small flyer at the front desk for members interested in grooming? Happy to follow any rules you have.'
5. **Coach or team lead:** 'Hi [Name], I cut hair in [Area]. If any of your players want a neat cut before the next game, I can offer short slots on [Day]. Parents are welcome to stay. Let me know if that would be useful.'

6. **School or event organizer:** 'Hello [Name], I am a barber in [Area]. I would be glad to offer pre-event cuts for [Event] if that fits your plans. Can we talk about timing and what is allowed at the venue?'
7. **Asking for a referral:** 'Thanks for coming in, [Name]. If you know anyone who might want a cut like this, send them my way. I would be happy to take care of them.'
8. **Asking for a review:** 'Hi [Name], it was great to cut your hair. If you have a minute, an honest review on my page would help a lot. Here is the link: [Link]. Thank you!'
9. **Reminder before an appointment:** 'Hi [Name], this is a reminder of your appointment on [Day] at [Time]. If anything changes, please let me know by [Time] so I can offer the slot to someone else.'
10. **Re-booking after a visit:** 'Hi [Name], it has been about [Number] weeks since your last cut. I have openings on [Day] and [Day]. Want me to book you in?'

9. How to Run a Great Appointment

A good haircut can be undone by a poor experience. Consistency in how you greet, listen, and finish makes people come back.

The 2-minute consultation

1. Greet the client and ask what they want. Let them describe it in their own words.
2. Look at photos if they bring any. Reference photos help avoid misunderstandings.
3. Feel the hair and check the head shape, growth patterns, cowlicks, and hairline.
4. Check for skin issues, moles, cuts, or irritation in the area you will work on. Avoid working directly over them.
5. Repeat back the plan: 'So we are doing a mid fade, leaving about an inch on top, and a clean neckline. Does that sound right?'
6. Confirm the price and timing if it was not stated before.
7. Ask about allergies or skin sensitivities before using products.

Hygiene and safety every time

- Wash your hands before each client, and clean them again after the service.
- Use a clean cape and fresh neck strip or towel for every person.
- Clean and disinfect tools between clients following the product's directions and your local rules. Remove hair first, then disinfect.
- Use a new blade for razor work and dispose of used blades safely in a sharps container, not loose in the trash.
- Wear gloves when you work near broken skin or when your local rules require them.
- Keep your station tidy. Sweep after every client.
- Do not work when you are sick, and ask clients with visible skin conditions to see a medical professional rather than treating the area.

If you accidentally nick the skin

Stop. Put on gloves. Apply gentle pressure with clean gauze or a clean tissue to stop the bleeding. Do not reuse that blade or tool until it has been cleaned and disinfected properly (single-use blades must be thrown away). Tell the client calmly, and follow local rules for cleaning up any blood. For deep cuts or bleeding that will not stop, suggest medical help.

Time management

- Book appointment slots with a buffer for cleanup and delays.
- Tell new clients how long a visit takes.
- Do not rush finishing steps like the neckline, the edges, and the check in the mirror.
- Give a clean finish: brush the neck, remove loose hair, and show the back with a hand mirror.
- Say what you did, and share a simple care tip, such as how often to book next.

10. Reviews and Referrals

Reviews help strangers decide to trust you. Ask honestly and at the right time.

How to ask

- Ask right after the visit, while the client is still happy with the cut.
- Make it easy by sending a direct link to your listing.
- Ask for honest feedback, not only five stars.
- Never pay for reviews, write your own, or trade discounts for positive ones where the platform forbids it.
- Reply to every review. Thank people who praise you, and answer criticism calmly and professionally.
- Learn from complaints. If three people say the same thing, fix it.

Referrals

Thank people who send you someone new. A quick message, a small discount on their next visit, or a simple 'thank you' can be enough. Keep any referral program fair, and clear, and make sure it follows the rules of the platform where you promote it.

11. Retention and Booking

It is cheaper and easier to keep a client than to find a new one. Most men return every few weeks, so a good system helps you stay booked.

Booking systems

- Use a simple calendar, notebook, or booking app. The best tool is the one you will check every day.

- Ask for the client's name and a way to reach them, and store it securely. Respect privacy laws and never share their details.
- Offer to book the next visit before they leave. 'Same time in three weeks?' works well.
- Keep clear business hours and tell clients when you are available.

Reminders

Send a short reminder a day before. It reduces no-shows and shows professionalism. Include the date, time, and a polite way to change plans.

Packages and loyalty

Some barbers offer a package, such as paying for several visits at a small discount, or a loyalty card with a reward after a number of visits. If you do, write the terms clearly: what it includes, when it expires, and whether it can be refunded. Check your local rules about prepaid services before you sell them.

Keep notes

After each visit, jot down the guards you used, the length on top, and anything the client likes or dislikes. Next time you can say 'Same as last time?' and get it right. Clients remember when you remember.

12. A Cancellation Policy

Late cancellations and no-shows cost you an empty chair. A clear, polite policy protects your time without making people feel unwelcome.

What to include

- How much notice you need to cancel or reschedule, such as 24 hours.
- What happens if someone is late. For example, you may shorten the service or rebook.
- What happens after repeated no-shows, such as asking for a deposit next time.
- An exception for real emergencies, handled kindly.

> **Sample wording**
>
> 'Please give at least [Hours] hours notice to cancel or reschedule so I can offer your slot to someone else. If you arrive more than [Minutes] minutes late, I may need to shorten your service or rebook. Thank you for understanding.' Share it when they book, not after a problem happens.

If you charge a fee or deposit, check your local consumer rules and be transparent about the amount before the booking is confirmed.

13. Common Mistakes to Avoid

1. **Skipping the consultation.** Most unhappy clients were never asked what they wanted.

2. **Cutting without checking local rules.** Working without a required license or permit can lead to fines and trouble.
3. **Poor sanitation.** Dirty tools and stations can harm clients and ruin a reputation.
4. **Posting photos without permission.** Always ask.
5. **Underpricing forever.** Low prices help at the start, but plan a gradual increase.
6. **Overpromising.** Do not promise a style your hair type or your current skill cannot produce.
7. **Ignoring feedback.** Complaints show where to improve.
8. **Not tracking money.** Keep records of income, costs, and taxes from the first client.
9. **Trying every trend at once.** Get very good at a few core cuts first.
10. **Quitting too early.** Slow weeks are normal. Keep practicing and showing your work.

14. Your 30-Day Action Plan

Use these checklists as a guide. Adjust them to your situation and local rules. Tick each item as you finish it.

WEEK 1: FOUNDATIONS

☐ Look up local licensing and business requirements and write down the answers

☐ Contact an insurance professional and ask about coverage options

☐ Set up a clean, organized station and a disinfecting routine

☐ Choose a booking method, such as a calendar or app

☐ Start your practice log

☐ Decide where you plan to work: shop, rented chair, or mobile (where allowed)

WEEK 2: PRACTICE AND PORTFOLIO

☐ Practice at least three sessions on mannequins or consenting models, where local rules allow

☐ Do a 2-minute consultation at every session

☐ Take front, profile, back, and top photos with permission

☐ Review your photos and choose your best six

☐ Ask a trusted, experienced barber for feedback

WEEK 3: ONLINE PRESENCE

☐ Create or tidy your social profile with a clear name, photo, and bio

☐ Post your first three portfolio pieces with permission

☐ Set up your business listing and start verification if it is available in your area

☐ Write a simple price list based on your calculation and local market

☐ Write your cancellation policy

WEEK 4: FIRST CLIENTS

☐ Message friends and family using the scripts in this guide

☐ Reach out to one gym, team, or local group

☐ Book at least three clients and give each a full, clean service

☐ Ask each client for feedback, a review, and a referral

☐ Book follow-up appointments before clients leave

☐ Review the month: what worked, what to fix, and what to repeat

15. Next Step

Pick the first checklist item you have not done yet and do it today. Small, steady actions add up: one practiced cut, one clean photo, one polite message. Keep your hygiene high, follow your local rules, and treat every client as the start of a long relationship. Review your practice log each week, and keep studying your lessons as you work.